

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

THE MYTH IS REAL

Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, **Rahul Gandhi**, has come in for praise from his peers for his speeches in the new Lok Sabha session. On July 1, he participated in the discussion on the motion of thanks to the President's address, while on July 28, he delivered a scathing critique of Union finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman's Budget. His speeches, infused with references from Indian mythology, have sparked much intrigue on who is writing them. Insiders claim Rahul meticulously drafts notes to integrate into his speeches. And the mythology bug is real. A South Indian Congress leader recounted a flight to Delhi years ago where Rahul engaged him on the philosophical contrasts in the gods Vishnu and Shiva. Incidentally, the Gandhi scion identifies himself as a Shaivite.

Ethical Irony

In the 17th Lok Sabha, the Ethics Committee's report on the cash-for-query scandal called out TMC MP **Mahua Moitra** for alleged "unethical conduct", leading to her expulsion in January 2024. The committee, led by BJP MP Vinod K. Sonkar, faced a fierce backlash from the Opposition for it. Fast forward five months, and Moitra was back in Parliament, but what about the 15 committee members? Only five managed a return ticket. Sonkar and three other BJP MPs—Subhash Bhamre, Sumedhanand Saraswati and Preneet Kaur—were felled by the mandate while two others didn't even get a ticket. Seems like Mahua had the last laugh in this battle.



ANI

Dreaming Big

The river Musi as the new Thames and Mucherla as New York? A visit to London this January had Telangana CM **A. Revanth Reddy** dreaming some big dreams. On June 20, he put his money where his mouth is, pledging Rs 1.5 lakh crore to transform Greater Hyderabad and revitalise the river. The CM is now travelling to the US (Aug. 3-11) to seek funds, and not just for this project. He wants investors to make good on the commitments of Rs 40,000 crore they had pledged at the WEF in Davos this January.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

DIDI DELIVERS

West Bengal CM **Mamata Banerjee** may seem like a tough negotiator to allies and rivals, but recently she stepped in to settle a spat in the Bengali film industry (proving she's also a potential peacemaker). The cine technicians' federation and the one for directors had faced off over the former's ban on filmmaker Rahool Mukherjee for 'breaking the rules'. With industry bigwigs Prosenjit Chatterjee, Dev (also a TMC MP) and Goutam Ghose rushing to the CM, the drama was resolved in hours. A committee has now been set up to monitor both the federations. When all else fails, Didi prevails.





THACKERAY TANGO

The 'fickle politician' trope is by now part of the lexicon but Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) chief **Raj Thackeray** seems to be taking it to a whole new level. The MNS chief's latest is that his party will contest the state assembly elections alone. In the Lok Sabha election, it had backed the ruling Mahayuti coalition, going back on its surrogate campaign in 2019 for the Congress and NCP. Before that, in 2014, Raj had supported Narendra Modi's prime ministerial campaign while still putting up candidates against the BJP's Lok Sabha nominees.

Kaushik Deka with Amarnath K. Menon, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Dhaval S. Kulkarni